

What are some CV essentials?

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File Format

It is always a good idea to send your CV as a PDF rather than as a Microsoft Word document. PDFs are the only file format you can be reasonably sure the reader will see exactly as you wrote it.

If you send a file in Microsoft Word format, the reader may not have the same fonts installed on their computer. This can make a two-page document become three pages, and it can cause all sorts of unpleasant visual problems for your carefully crafted document. ;-)

Typography

Avoid using all caps, especially in your name. The reader may want to select and copy your name from your CV to paste it into a report. If your name is in all caps, it will be pasted in all caps. That is not a good look.

Do not underline anything unless it is actually a clickable link.

Feel free to use **bold lettering** and *italics*. Even better, why not use color and more fonts? Why not use emoji?

Font size is a fascinating issue. If your target audience is, say, 30 or under, use the tightest, smallest font possible, because older people may struggle to read it. But if your target audience is your boss's boss, write for their eyes, and use the largest, most open font possible.

Style

There are a zillion templates for creating your own résumé. My personal feeling is that most of them are full of decorations and space fillers because most people's résumés do not have enough content. If you have plenty of content, you do not need to fill up space with decorations. Use that space for substance instead.

Choose your own fonts. Use a different headline font and a different text font. Use Microsoft Word styles to ensure that the different bullets and headings all have the same style. Or, even better, mix different fonts and styles and make your résumé a work of art.

Mostly, I try to keep everything left-justified. I even reduce the margin between the left margin and the bullet in a bullet list because I feel that space is wasted.

I play with the margins and adjust lots of details. The more you do this, the more it feels like it was made by a human.

Interaction

The typical résumés I see look and feel like sheets of paper. Interestingly, most of them are PDFs sent by email, but they still look like paper. No, no, no!

Your life is much more than a sheet of paper. Make your PDF as interactive as possible.

- All links should be clickable.
- The titles of every organization you work for should be a link to that organization's website.
- Ditto for every educational institution you attended.
- Did you win an award or publish an article? Make sure these efforts are included, and the title should be a link.

Content

IIRC, I have often read that a CV should be one page only. I guess that is fine for someone who is just leaving college and has not done that much. But if you had a life like mine, trying to compress my life into one page would be a waste of time.

So for a while, I thought my résumés could be as long as I wanted them to be. My thinking has shifted again.

So now I have compromised. I think the longest form would be nice — perhaps two pages, with the idea that it could be printed on both sides of one sheet of paper if needed. This is because:

If you are a modern thinker, your résumé is just a "trailer" for the much more interesting life that you have created online. You will share that life through the links you include in your paper.

Who Are You?

I have no idea how you are going to do this. I am not you, and you are not me. But every résumé I have ever prepared has some feeling that this is just Theo's résumé, of course. Fingers crossed, you can find ways of adding some of the magic that is **Sylvester**.